

to the cloud.” It is more selective than that, and that is both a strength and a limitation.

Its strength is that it helps make a new or refreshed Windows PC feel recognisable quickly. Your theme, some app restoration behaviour, Wi-Fi credentials, and backed-up folders help reduce the sense that you have been digitally reborn against your will. Its limitation is that this is not the same as a full disk image or a perfect clone of everything on your computer. If you have large media folders sitting outside backed-up locations, or special project archives stored in random custom directories, Windows Backup alone may not rescue them the way you imagine. Microsoft’s own documentation frames it as a one-stop solution for “many of the things that are most important,” not literally everything.

That is why the right mindset is this: Windows Backup restores continuity; your own file strategy restores confidence. You want both.

The heart of Windows backup is really folders

For most home users, what matters most is not exotic system-state perfection. It is the ordinary stuff: Desktop files, Documents, Pictures, maybe Videos, and all the little digital scraps that become terrifyingly important only after they are gone. This is where OneDrive becomes central. Microsoft’s OneDrive documentation specifically describes PC folder backup for Desktop, Documents and Pictures, allowing those folders to be backed up and synced to OneDrive. Microsoft also highlights this feature in its OneDrive help hub as one of the core ways to protect important folders automatically.



This is the first big Windows truth readers need to absorb: if your essential files live inside the folders Microsoft is actively designed to protect, your life gets easier. If your most precious work is scattered across Downloads, random drive roots, unnamed folders on D:, and a labyrinth of “temporary” locations, backup becomes less automatic and more theatrical.

Step-by-step: turn on Windows Backup

1. Open Settings in Windows 11.
2. Go to Accounts.
3. Click Windows backup.
4. Review the categories Microsoft offers, including files, apps, settings, credentials, and preferences.
5. Make sure the relevant backup options are switched on. Microsoft says you can also use the dedicated Windows Backup app for this setup.

That is the starting point. But do not stop there.

Turn on OneDrive folder backup for the folders that matter

If you do one serious thing after reading this chapter, do this. Microsoft’s official OneDrive instructions say you can back up your PC folders so that Desktop, Documents, and Pictures are synced to OneDrive. Once enabled, those files are available through OneDrive and far easier to carry over to another PC. Microsoft also documents how to manage, stop, or troubleshoot PC folder backup if issues arise later.

Step-by-step: set up OneDrive folder backup

1. Make sure you are signed in to OneDrive with your Microsoft account.
2. Open the OneDrive app or icon from the Windows taskbar area.
3. Go into OneDrive settings.
4. Find the option to manage or start folder backup.
5. Select Desktop, Documents, and Pictures as appropriate.
6. Confirm the setup and allow the initial sync to complete. Microsoft’s documentation describes this as the core PC folder backup flow.

Why is this so important? Because an enormous percentage of Windows users dump critical files onto the Desktop as if it were an emotional support shelf. Normally, that is bad practice. With OneDrive folder backup enabled, it becomes a survivable vice.

What Windows Backup is brilliant at

Microsoft’s own pitch is not wrong. Windows Backup is genuinely useful for people replacing laptops, resetting Windows, or recovering after a failure. Microsoft says it can preserve themes, settings, installed apps, Wi-Fi info and files, and its “transfer your files and settings to a new Windows PC” guidance specifically directs users to open the Windows Backup app on the old PC before migration. This makes Windows Backup particularly strong for people who want a less painful move to a new machine.

It is also good for everyday resilience. If your folders are syncing properly to OneDrive and Windows Backup is preserving settings and preferences, a new laptop setup becomes